

Instructional Leadership Experience

MavPASS Leader | Tutor | Teaching Assistant

By Joel Tchouke

I served as a MavPASS leader at Minnesota State University, Mankato. A MavPASS leader is a peer that previously passed a particular class and now tutors or mentors students currently taking that class by offering additional practice sessions and guidance. This was my first real instructional role. Through this experience I discovered how to communicate effectively and how to lead sessions in a way where my team would come out a little less confused than when they entered. In this reflection, I explore the experiences and skills I gained during that time that contributed to my development as a leader.

I began my MavPASS journey when I was just a sophomore. I started by leading sessions for Electrical Engineering 106, the entry-level class of the Electrical and Computer Engineering curriculum. It is a foundational course that prepares students for the four years of coursework ahead. Because of that, the responsibility felt significant. At the time, I did not know much about teaching or tutoring. My only experience was occasionally helping friends in high school with challenging subjects. I initially doubted whether I had the skills required to lead a group of students effectively.

However, the MavPASS training program quickly helped me realize that I already possessed qualities that could make me a strong leader. The training also helped me develop the skills I did not yet have. Jeff and Laura, the program's co-coordinator and coordinator, along with the rest of the MavPASS staff, played an important role in developing both my abilities and my confidence as a MavPASS leader.

One of the first responsibilities of a MavPASS leader is to connect with the professor teaching the course and design a tailored study plan for the students. This process taught me how to collaborate with faculty and how to adapt my work to meet the needs of a specific group. For example, during the year I began MavPASS, I was paired with Professor Shirk, who taught EE106. During our first meeting we discussed trends observed in previous semesters and identified the areas where students struggled the most. We listed common challenges and exchanged ideas on how to address them.

After these discussions, I would meet with my MavPASS coach—essentially a supervisor for the program—or sometimes with Jeff or Laura to determine the best strategy moving forward. Together we developed a detailed plan for the semester: what topics to emphasize, what teaching

strategies to use, and what exercises and activities would best help students develop mastery. This process was extremely valuable because it taught me how to analyze a team's needs, communicate effectively with mentors and supervisors, and develop structured strategies to achieve goals.

However, these goals were not always easy to reach. Many adjustments and iterations were required throughout the semester as I refined my approach based on student performance and feedback.

Another major component of the MavPASS program is fostering an environment of collaboration. The purpose of MavPASS is not to lecture or reteach the course material. Instead, the goal is to create a collaborative space where students work together to solve problems and strengthen their understanding. The MavPASS leader acts primarily as a facilitator rather than a traditional instructor.

This approach was challenging for me at first. Because I tend to be compassionate and eager to help, my instinct was to jump in quickly whenever students were struggling. However, over time I realized something important: when students simply watch someone else solve a problem or receive answers too easily, they do not fully develop their own understanding of the concept.

Early in the semester, coaches who observed my sessions noticed that I sometimes intervened too quickly and solved problems for the students myself. Receiving that feedback was an important moment for me. It was one of the first times in my college career where I had to adjust my leadership style because my actions were directly impacting other people's learning.

I began modifying my strategies. Instead of explaining solutions immediately, I designed activities that encouraged students to work collaboratively with minimal intervention from me. One example was a "tic-tac-toe" style activity where students worked in teams and solved problems together to compete against other groups. These types of activities naturally shifted the responsibility of learning back to the students.

As I improved in this skill of transferring responsibility from myself to the students, the results became visible. Students increasingly reported that their understanding improved with every session, even though I was speaking less and primarily guiding the collaboration. Coaches also noticed the change and appreciated the more relaxed and supportive environment I created during sessions. By stepping back, I was able to build confidence in my students and show them that difficult problems could be approached step by step.

Through this experience I learned that effective leadership is not about controlling every aspect of the process. Instead, effective leadership is about empowering the people you lead and creating an environment where they can succeed independently through trust, collaboration, and support. Although it was rewarding to see students leave sessions with greater understanding than when

they arrived, learning to remain patient and allow students to struggle productively required discipline and strong situational awareness.

As a MavPASS leader, I also had to navigate challenging interpersonal situations. In every group of students there are individuals with different expectations of what a learning session should look like. Sometimes this can lead to friction.

One particular experience stands out. I had a student—whom I will refer to as X—who strongly disagreed with my leadership style. X expected the sessions to function more like a tutoring session where answers would be provided directly. Because my approach focused on collaboration and student-driven problem solving, this student often resisted instructions during sessions. X would sometimes refuse to participate in activities, interrupt collaborative work, or challenge my approach in front of the group.

These moments were particularly difficult because they occasionally occurred when coaches were observing my sessions. At first, I was unsure how to react in these situations. However, after these sessions the coaches consistently praised how I handled the interactions. They noted that I remained calm, avoided escalating the situation, and continued encouraging X to participate while maintaining a respectful environment for the rest of the group.

Rather than responding defensively, I focused on keeping the session productive. I redirected conversations back to the task, encouraged collaboration among the other students, and continued inviting X to contribute in a positive way. Over time, I began to notice a reduction in the disruptive behavior. Eventually, X became more engaged with the group and participated more constructively.

This experience taught me an important lesson about leadership. Leadership that expects the best from a team must also demonstrate patience and compassion. By remaining calm and respectful, I was able to gradually earn the cooperation of a student who initially resisted the structure of the sessions. At the same time, I learned that effective leadership must also establish clear expectations and boundaries. Compassion and patience are essential, but leaders must also clearly communicate what behaviors are acceptable in order to maintain a productive environment.

As I gained experience in the program, my role also expanded to supporting other courses. In addition to leading sessions for EE106, I later worked with Professor Bhushan and Professor Muhammed for Circuit Analysis I (EE230). This experience introduced a new challenge because the course material was more mathematically rigorous and students often struggled with complex analytical techniques such as node analysis, mesh analysis, and circuit theorems. Working with multiple instructors also required me to adapt my preparation and session design to different teaching styles and course expectations. This further strengthened my ability to adjust my leadership approach based on the needs of both the students and the instructor.

Even after I was no longer actively leading sessions, I would occasionally encounter former students on campus who had attended my MavPASS sessions. Some of them would stop me and mention that the sessions had played a significant role in helping them understand the course material. A few even told me directly that the collaborative approach we used during the sessions was the moment when the concepts began to make sense to them. Hearing those comments was deeply rewarding because it confirmed that the effort put into designing collaborative and supportive learning environments had a real impact on students' success.

By the end of my time in the program, the MavPASS staff recognized my development and invited me to serve as a Peer Mentor. A Peer Mentor serves as an intermediate role between a MavPASS leader and a coach. Peer Mentors help newer leaders develop their leadership and facilitation skills while also coordinating activities within groups of MavPASS leaders.

In this role, my responsibilities shifted from primarily leading sessions to supporting other leaders in their growth. I would attend other MavPASS leaders' sessions, observe their facilitation style, and take notes on both strengths and areas for improvement. After the sessions, I provided constructive feedback similar to what my own coaches had provided to me earlier in my journey. It was gratifying to be able to help my peers and help them grow in their skills. I developed my observations and critical thinking as decoding what was good from what was not was quite analytical

During these observations, I was able to see several different leadership styles in action. One example of an effective leadership approach was a leader who used structured questioning to guide students through difficult problems. Instead of providing answers directly, the leader would ask a sequence of small questions that helped students identify the next logical step in the solution. I noticed that this approach encouraged students to remain engaged and gave them a sense of ownership over the problem-solving process. The students were actively discussing ideas with each other rather than simply waiting for the leader to explain the solution. Observing this technique reinforced for me how powerful guided questioning can be in helping students develop confidence and deeper understanding.

At the same time, I also observed leadership styles that were less effective. In one session I attended, the leader tended to dominate the conversation by explaining the solutions too quickly. Although the explanations were technically correct, the students became passive listeners rather than active participants. Several students stopped attempting the problems themselves and instead waited for the leader to complete the work on the board. After the session, I reflected on how this style unintentionally limited student engagement. It reminded me of the feedback I had received earlier in my own journey about intervening too quickly. Seeing this situation from the outside helped me better understand why facilitation, rather than direct instruction, is such an important part of the MavPASS model.

These observations helped me recognize how small differences in leadership approach can significantly influence how a group learns and interacts. Leaders who created space for students to think, collaborate, and struggle productively tended to generate more engagement and confidence among the group. In contrast, sessions where the leader took too much control often resulted in quieter and less interactive groups. Being able to observe these contrasts allowed me to develop a clearer understanding of effective facilitation and helped me provide more meaningful feedback to the leaders I was mentoring.

This experience allowed me to see leadership from another perspective. Instead of focusing only on improving my own performance, I now had the responsibility of helping others refine their leadership approaches. It required me to analyze teaching styles, understand different challenges leaders were facing, and communicate feedback in a way that was supportive and constructive.

Serving as a Peer Mentor reinforced many of the leadership lessons I had learned earlier. I realized that leadership development is a continuous process that requires reflection, feedback, and adaptation. Just as my coaches had helped me grow into a stronger facilitator, I now had the opportunity to contribute to the growth of other leaders.

I gradually realized that leadership is never finished. No leader is perfect, and there is always room for improvement. During my time as a Peer Mentor, I had the opportunity to observe other MavPASS leaders in their sessions and reflect on their teaching styles. Some of these leaders were individuals I considered much stronger and more experienced than I was when I first started in the program. However, what impressed me the most was their humility. Even when I provided feedback or suggested small adjustments to their sessions, they were willing to listen and thoughtfully consider those ideas.

Seeing leaders with more experience than me remain open to feedback reinforced an important lesson. Leadership is not about reaching a point where one has mastered everything. Instead, it is a continuous process of learning, reflecting, and improving. True leadership requires the willingness to listen, to adapt, and to remain open to suggestions that can make both the leader and the team stronger. Through these experiences, I came to understand that growth does not stop once someone becomes a leader. In many ways, leadership simply opens the door to a new level of learning and development.

Looking back, my experience as a MavPASS leader and later as a Peer Mentor was one of the most formative leadership experiences of my college career. It strengthened my ability to communicate complex ideas clearly, taught me how to facilitate collaborative learning environments, and helped me develop patience and adaptability when working with students from diverse academic backgrounds and learning styles. These experiences pushed me to become more attentive to how people learn and how different leadership approaches can influence the success of a group. Most importantly, they showed me that effective leadership is not about providing all

the answers. Instead, it is about guiding others toward discovering those answers themselves and creating an environment where individuals feel capable and confident in their own abilities.

This realization naturally leads me to reflect on how these lessons will shape my leadership moving forward. The experiences I gained through MavPASS will influence how I approach leadership in future academic, professional, and collaborative environments. As I continue my career in engineering, I expect to work in teams where solving complex problems will require strong collaboration and communication. The facilitation skills I developed through MavPASS—encouraging participation, guiding discussion, and helping others build confidence in their problem-solving abilities—are directly applicable to those environments.

In the future, I hope to apply these lessons by fostering the same type of collaborative atmosphere that MavPASS encouraged. Whether working on engineering projects, research teams, or professional organizations, I want to approach leadership as a process of empowering others rather than directing them. I want to create environments where people feel comfortable sharing ideas, asking questions, and learning from one another. My experience also taught me the importance of patience and situational awareness when working with individuals who may approach problems differently or struggle in different ways.

Additionally, the role of Peer Mentor showed me the value of supporting the development of other leaders. In the future, I hope to continue mentoring others in academic and professional settings. Just as my coaches and mentors helped me refine my leadership abilities, I hope to provide guidance and encouragement to others who are developing their own leadership styles. Helping others grow not only strengthens individuals but also builds stronger teams and communities.

Ultimately, my experience as a MavPASS leader shaped the way I view leadership. It taught me that leadership is not defined by authority or expertise, but by the ability to support the growth of others. The most meaningful moments during my time in the program were not when I solved problems for students, but when I watched them gain confidence and realize that they were capable of solving those problems themselves. That lesson will continue to guide how I approach leadership in every environment I encounter in the future.